Functional equations at BMO2 and IMO level

Kevin Hu
November 2026

L5-AL2 Level 5 Advanced · Algebra

Functional equations with no regularity handed to you include Cauchy with a boundedness condition, where that condition hides in an equation, involutions and the pointwise trap, fixed points, equations on the integers, and complete write-ups.
By the end you can prove that a bounded or monotone additive function is linear, and find the hidden regularity in an equation over the reals; extract injectivity, surjectivity, involutions and shifts, and rule out pointwise mixtures of solutions; solve equations on the integers using shifts, positivity and injectivity, and write a complete 'find all' solution.
Prerequisites: Functional equations (L4-AL1). **Contests:** BMO Round 2, EGMO and IMO selection, USAMO, IMO. **Time:** about 180 minutes.

1 Lesson

Find all functions f from the positive reals to the positive reals such that

$$f\big(x+f(y)\big)=f(x)+2y \quad \text{for all } x,y>0.$$

If $f(a)=f(b)$, comparing the equation at (x,a) and (x,b) gives $2a=2b$, so f is injective. Applying the equation twice,

$$f\big(x+f(y)+f(z)\big)=f\big(x+f(y)\big)+2z=f(x)+2y+2z=f\big(x+f(y+z)\big),$$

and injectivity gives $f(y)+f(z)=f(y+z)$. So f is additive on the positive reals. Since f takes positive values, $f(y+z)>f(y)$, so f is increasing. Additivity gives $f(q)=kq$ for positive rationals q, where $k=f(1)$, and for real x and rationals $p<x<q$ we get $kp<f(x)<kq$. Letting $p,q\to x$ gives $f(x)=kx$. Substituting, $k^2=2$, so $f(x)=\sqrt{2}\,x$, which works.

Now change the domain and codomain to $\mathbb{R}$. The same argument shows f is additive with $f(f(y))=2y$, and every such function is a solution. But the step "positive values, so increasing" is gone, and there are additive functions f with $f(f(y))=2y$ for all y that are not of the form kx (they are built from a basis of $\mathbb{R}$ over $\mathbb{Q}$, using the axiom of choice). So over $\mathbb{R}$ the answer is not $\pm\sqrt{2}\,x$, but a set of functions you cannot write down. Problem setters at this level avoid such equations, so an olympiad equation over $\mathbb{R}$ almost always contains something that forces regularity. Finding that something is the main subject of this unit. We assume L4-AL1 (substitutions, injectivity, Cauchy over $\mathbb{Q}$).

1.1 Additive functions and regularity

Call $f:\mathbb{R}\to\mathbb{R}$ additive if $f(x+y)=f(x)+f(y)$ for all x,y. From L4-AL1, an additive f satisfies $f(qx)=qf(x)$ for all rational q and real x.

© 2026 Kevin Hu · kevinvariant08.github.io · CC BY-NC-ND 4.0

Kevinvariant
kevinvariant08.github.io

Theorem 1.
Let f be additive and bounded above (or bounded below) on some interval (a,b). Then $f(x) = cx$ for all x, where $c = f(1)$.
Proof. Replacing f by $-f$ if necessary, suppose $f \le M$ on (a,b). Let $g(x) = f(x) - cx$. Then g is additive, $g(q) = 0$ for rational q, and $g \le M' = M + |c|(|a| + |b|)$ on (a,b). Fix a real x and a positive integer n, and choose a rational q with $nx + q \in (a,b)$. Then $ng(x) = g(nx+q) \le M'$. The same with $-x$ gives $-ng(x) \le M'$. Hence $|g(x)| \le M'/n$ for every n, so $g(x) = 0$.

In particular a monotone additive function is linear, and so is an additive function that is non-negative on $[0,\infty)$. In an olympiad equation, the regularity comes from one of the following.

1. A positive codomain, as in the opening problem.
2. Squares. A relation such as $f(x^2) = f(x)^2$ gives $f \ge 0$ on $[0,\infty)$.
3. A polynomial identity. If f is additive and satisfies an identity involving products like $xf(x)$, replace x by $x+q$ with q rational. Both sides become polynomials in q, and comparing coefficients gives new relations, often linear ones (Polynomial comparison).

Example 1.
Find all functions $f : \mathbb{R} \to \mathbb{R}$ such that $f(x^3 + y) = x^2 f(x) + f(y)$ for all real x, y.

Solution.
Every $f(x) = kx$ works, since $k(x^3+y) = x^2 \cdot kx + ky$. We show there are no others. Let $c = f(0)$. Putting $y = 0$ gives $f(x^3) = x^2 f(x) + c$, so the equation reads $f(x^3+y) = f(x^3) + f(y) - c$. Every real number is a cube, so $g = f - c$ is additive, that is, $g(t+y) = g(t) + g(y)$ for all t, y. Then $f(x^3) = x^2 f(x) + c$ becomes $g(x^3) = x^2 g(x) + cx^2$, and $x = 1$ gives $c = 0$. So f is additive and $f(x^3) = x^2 f(x)$.
Additivity alone allows wild solutions, so the identity must be used. Replace x by $x+1$ and expand both sides using additivity, with $a = f(1)$:

$$f(x^3) + 3f(x^2) + 3f(x) + a = (x+1)^2\big(f(x) + a\big).$$

Cancelling $f(x^3) = x^2 f(x)$ leaves

$$3f(x^2) + 2f(x) = 2xf(x) + (x^2 + 2x)a.$$

An unknown $f(x^2)$ remains, so we need a second relation. Replacing x by $-x$ (note f is odd) gives $3f(x^2) - 2f(x) = 2xf(x) + (x^2 - 2x)a$. Subtracting, $4f(x) = 4ax$. Hence $f(x) = ax$, and the solutions are $f(x) = kx$ for every real k.
No inequality was needed, because the term $x^2 f(x)$ mixes f with multiplication by x, and a wild additive function cannot satisfy such an identity.

1.2 Injectivity, involutions and the pointwise trap

The first substitutions at this level are the same as in L4-AL1, but the aim is different. Before computing anything, extract structure. A relation $f(f(y)) = y + c$ gives a bijection, and if $c = 0$ then f is an involution, and you may replace y by $f(y)$ anywhere. A zero $f(z) = 0$ (which exists if f is surjective) is usually worth substituting. If $f(f(x)) = x$, every value of f is matched, because f swaps x and $f(x)$, and the fixed points of f are the x with $f(x) = x$.

Kevinvariant
kevinvariant08.github.io

The trap is the same as at Level 4, with harder equations. From $f(x)^2 = x^2$ for all x you know only that for each x separately, $f(x) = x$ or $f(x) = -x$. To finish, assume $f(a) = -a$ and $f(b) = b$ for some nonzero a, b, and derive a contradiction or the structure of all such a, b.

Example 2.
Find all functions $f : \mathbb{R} \to \mathbb{R}$ such that $f\big(f(x)^3 + f(y)\big) = x^3 + y$ for all real x, y.

Solution.
Both $f(x) = x$ and $f(x) = -x$ work, since for $f(x) = -x$ the left side is $f(-x^3 - y) = x^3 + y$.
Write $P(x, y)$ for the equation and let $c = f(0)$. $P(0, y)$ gives $f\big(c^3 + f(y)\big) = y$, so f is surjective, and if $f(y_1) = f(y_2)$ then the same identity gives $y_1 = y_2$. Hence f is a bijection.
Let z be the number with $f(z) = 0$. Then $P(z, y)$ gives

$$f(f(y)) = y + z^3. \qquad (1)$$

Applying f to $f\big(c^3 + f(y)\big) = y$ and using (1) on the left, $c^3 + f(y) + z^3 = f(y)$, so $z^3 = -c^3$ and $z = -c$.
Next, $P(x, z)$ and $P(x, 0)$ give $f\big(f(x)^3\big) = x^3 - c$ and $f\big(f(x)^3 + c\big) = x^3$. Since f is surjective and every real number is a cube of a real number, $f(x)^3$ takes every real value t, so $f(t + c) = f(t) + c$ for all t. At $t = 0$ this gives $f(c) = 2c$, while (1) at $y = 0$ gives $f(c) = f(f(0)) = z^3 = -c^3$. Hence $c(c^2 + 2) = 0$, and so $c = 0$.
So $f(0) = 0$, $f(f(y)) = y$ and $f\big(f(x)^3\big) = x^3$. Replacing x by $f(x)$ in the last relation gives

$$f(x^3) = f(x)^3. \qquad (2)$$

Now $P(x, f(y))$ reads $f\big(f(x)^3 + y\big) = x^3 + f(y) = f\big(f(x)^3\big) + f(y)$, and again $f(x)^3$ takes every real value, so $f(s + y) = f(s) + f(y)$ for all s, y. Thus f is additive.
Additivity alone allows wild solutions, so (2) must be used, by polynomial comparison as in Example 1. Let $\varepsilon = f(1)$. Then (2) at $x = 1$ gives $\varepsilon^3 = \varepsilon$, and $\varepsilon \neq 0$ because f is injective and $f(0) = 0$, so $\varepsilon = \pm 1$. For rational q, additivity gives

$$f\big((x + q)^3\big) = f(x^3) + 3qf(x^2) + 3q^2 f(x) + q^3\varepsilon,$$

while $\big(f(x + q)\big)^3 = \big(f(x) + q\varepsilon\big)^3 = f(x)^3 + 3q\varepsilon f(x)^2 + 3q^2 f(x) + q^3\varepsilon$, using $\varepsilon^2 = 1$. By (2) the two are equal, and taking $q = 1$ leaves $f(x^2) = \varepsilon f(x)^2$. Hence for $t \geq 0$ we get $\varepsilon f(t) = \varepsilon^2 f(\sqrt{t})^2 \geq 0$. The additive function εf is therefore bounded below on $(0, 1)$, and Theorem 1 gives $\varepsilon f(x) = \varepsilon f(1)\, x = x$. So $f(x) = \varepsilon x$, and the solutions are $f(x) = x$ and $f(x) = -x$.
The pointwise trap did not arise here, because additivity was proved before any square appeared, and then the sign is decided once, by the single number $f(1)$. When an equation yields $f(x)^2 = x^2$ before additivity is known, the argument of the previous paragraph is needed.

1.3 Equations on $\mathbb{N}$ and $\mathbb{Z}$

On the integers there is no regularity issue, and Cauchy's equation on $\mathbb{Z}$ gives $f(n) = nf(1)$ by induction. The difficulties are different. You cannot put $x = 0$ if 0 is not in the domain, you cannot divide, and the conclusion often depends on positivity of values. Standard tools are to show a shift $f(m + d) = f(m) + e$ and then compare shifts by different amounts (two shifts commute), to use that a positive integer sequence cannot decrease forever, and to use induction on n.

Kevinvariant
kevinvariant08.github.io

Example 3.
Find all functions f from the positive integers to the positive integers such that $f\big(m+f(n)\big)=f\big(f(m)\big)+n$ for all positive integers m,n.

Solution.
Trying $f(n)=n+e$ gives $m+n+2e$ on both sides, so every such function with $e\geq 0$ works. We show there are no others. If $f(n_1)=f(n_2)$, comparing $P(1,n_1)$ and $P(1,n_2)$ gives $n_1=n_2$, so f is injective. Let $a=f(1)$. $P(m,1)$ gives $f(f(m))=f(m+a)-1$, and the equation becomes

$$f\big(m+f(n)\big)=f(m+a)+n-1. \qquad (*)$$

With $n=2$ and $b=f(2)$, $(*)$ gives $f(m+b)=f(m+a)+1$ for all $m\geq 1$, and $b\neq a$.
If $b<a$, put $D=a-b$. Then $f(s+D)=f(s)-1$ for all $s\geq b+1$, so $f(s+kD)=f(s)-k$, which is negative for large k. This is impossible, so $b>a$, and with $D=b-a$ we get $f(s+kD)=f(s)+k$ for all $s\geq a+1$ and $k\geq 0$ (Two shifts). Hence $f(m+a)+n-1=f\big(m+a+(n-1)D\big)$, and $(*)$ with injectivity gives

$$f(n)=a+(n-1)D \quad \text{for all } n.$$

Substituting $f(n)=Dn+e$ with $e=a-D$ into the equation gives $Dm+D^2n+De+e=D^2m+De+e+n$, so $D=D^2$ and $D^2=1$, hence $D=1$. So $f(n)=n+e$ with $e=a-1\geq 0$, and we checked above that all of these work.
Positivity was used once, to rule out $b<a$. Over $\mathbb{Z}$ that case would need a different argument.

1.4 Fixed points

If the equation produces many points with $f(t)=t$, find what operations the set of fixed points is closed under (Fixed point method). The standard instance is $f:\mathbb{R}^+\to\mathbb{R}^+$ with $f\big(xf(y)\big)=yf(x)$, the equation of IMO 1983 Problem 1 (where the equation comes with the extra condition that $f(x)\to 0$ as $x\to\infty$). Putting $x=y=1$ gives $f(f(1))=f(1)$, and putting $x=1$ gives $f(f(y))=f(1)y$, so f is injective, and then $f(f(1))=f(1)$ gives $f(1)=1$ and $f(f(y))=y$. Putting $y=x$ gives $f\big(xf(x)\big)=xf(x)$, so every number $xf(x)$ is a fixed point. If a,b are fixed points, then $f(ab)=f\big(af(b)\big)=bf(a)=ab$, and $1=f(1)=f\big(\frac{1}{a}\cdot a\big)=f\big(\frac{1}{a}f(a)\big)=af\big(\frac{1}{a}\big)$, so $\frac{1}{a}$ is fixed. Hence if some fixed point $a\neq 1$ exists, all powers a^n ($n\in\mathbb{Z}$) are fixed points, and the set of fixed points is unbounded above. Whatever extra condition the problem gives (a limit, a bound, monotonicity) is then used against this unbounded set. In IMO 1983 this condition shows that 1 is the only fixed point, so $xf(x)=1$.

Note the structure. The equation alone allowed both $f(x)=x$ and $f(x)=\frac{1}{x}$ (and wild multiplicative involutions), and the extra condition chose between them through the fixed points.

1.5 The other Cauchy equations

Three relatives of Cauchy's equation reduce to that equation, and Theorem 1 transfers through the reduction.

1. $f:\mathbb{R}^+\to\mathbb{R}$ with $f(xy)=f(x)+f(y)$. Put $g(t)=f(e^t)$, and then g is additive on $\mathbb{R}$.
2. $f:\mathbb{R}\to\mathbb{R}^+$ with $f(x+y)=f(x)f(y)$. Put $g=\ln f$, and then g is additive. If f may take

Kevinvariant
kevinvariant08.github.io

the value 0, note that $f(x_0) = 0$ gives $f(x) = f(x_0)f(x - x_0) = 0$ for all x.

3. $f : \mathbb{R}^+ \to \mathbb{R}^+$ with $f(xy) = f(x)f(y)$. Put $g(t) = \ln f(e^t)$.

In each case a bound on f over an interval becomes a bound on g over an interval, so the regular solutions are $c \ln x$, e^{cx} and x^c respectively. On $\mathbb{R}$ rather than $\mathbb{R}^+$, the multiplicative equation also needs the sign of $f(-1)$ and the value $f(0)$, which you must find separately.

1.6 Writing a complete "find all"

A full-marks solution to a functional equation has the following shape.

1. State the answer at the start, and verify each solution for all values of the variables. Write the check out, since writing "easy to verify" loses marks when the check is not easy.
2. Name the substitutions, with $P(x, y)$ for the equation, then "$P(0, y)$ gives ...".
3. Prove every structural claim (injective, surjective, odd, additive) before using the claim, and never divide by $f(x)$ or x without dealing with the zero case.
4. If additivity appears over $\mathbb{R}$, say exactly which regularity condition you then prove, and prove that condition.
5. Rule out mixtures explicitly.

Common traps.

- Quoting "Cauchy's equation, so $f(x) = cx$" over $\mathbb{R}$ with no regularity. This is wrong, and markers treat this as a serious gap.
- The pointwise trap is that $f(x) \in \{x, -x\}$ for each x is not the same as $f(x) = x$ for all x or $f(x) = -x$ for all x.
- Using a value outside the domain, such as $m = 0$ on the positive integers.
- Claiming surjectivity from an expression that covers only part of the line, such as $f(f(y)) = y^2 + c$.
- Checking the answer at a few values instead of for all values.

1.7 How to spot this in a contest

BMO Round 2 often sets a functional equation (in 2009, 2019, 2022 and 2024, for example), frequently on the integers or the positive reals, and the IMO has set one in most years since 2008, usually over $\mathbb{R}$ or $\mathbb{R}^+$. In practice:

1. Guess the answers first (linear, constant, x^2, $1/x$) and check them, since the answer tells you which facts to aim for.
2. Look for an $f(f(\cdot))$ term or a variable appearing alone on one side, since these give injectivity or surjectivity.
3. When additivity appears, look at the equation for what can replace continuity, such as a positive codomain, a square, or a product with x.
4. On $\mathbb{N}$ and $\mathbb{Z}$, look for a shift, then use positivity, injectivity and induction.

Kevinvariant
kevinvariant08.github.io

5. Before writing up, ask whether any step was only pointwise.

2 Practice problems

The problems are roughly in order of difficulty, from ⋆⋆ to ⋆⋆⋆⋆. Hints are in Section 4 and full solutions in Section 5.

Problem 1 ⋆⋆ Find all functions $f : \mathbb{Z} \to \mathbb{Z}$ such that $f\big(f(m)+n\big) = m + f(n+2)$ for all integers m, n.

Problem 2 ⋆⋆ Find all functions $f : \mathbb{R} \to \mathbb{R}$ such that $f\big(xf(y)+f(x)\big) = xy$ for all real x, y.

Problem 3 ⋆⋆⋆ Prove that there is no function $f : \mathbb{R} \to \mathbb{R}$ such that $f\big(x+f(y)\big) = f(x)+y^2$ for all real x, y.

Problem 4 ⋆⋆⋆ Find all functions $f : \mathbb{R} \to \mathbb{R}$ such that $f\big(x^3+f(y)\big) = xf(x^2)+y$ for all real x, y.

Problem 5 ⋆⋆⋆⋆ Find all functions $f : \mathbb{R} \to \mathbb{R}$ such that $f(x^3+y) = f(x)^3+f(y)$ for all real x, y.

Problem 6 ⋆⋆⋆⋆ Find all functions $f : \mathbb{R} \to \mathbb{R}$ such that $f(x^2+y)+f(x) = f(x)f(x+1)+f(y)$ for all real x, y.

3 Contest ladder

Real past problems on the ideas of this unit, easiest first. Each source is a link to the official paper or the AoPS wiki; the note under it says where to start, not how to finish.

1. **BMO2 2023/24 Problem 2** ⋆⋆
   Iterate the relation along the orbit of n and solve the resulting linear recurrence, and integrality rules out one branch.
2. **BMO2 2008/09 Problem 3** ⋆⋆⋆
   Find f(0), then compare the substitutions y = 0, y = x and y = -x.
3. **BMO2 2018/19 Problem 4** ⋆⋆⋆
   Find f(1), then study g(x) = f(x) - x, and monotonicity of f is needed at the end.
4. **BMO2 2021/22 Problem 2** ⋆⋆⋆
   Vary y with x fixed. The left side is linear in y, so compare growth and divisibility.
5. **IMO 2010 Problem 1** ⋆⋆⋆
   Substitute values with floor 0 and floor 1, and split according to whether the floor of some value is zero.
6. **IMO 2019 Problem 1** ⋆⋆⋆
   Two substitutions with the same value of a + b give a linear relation between values of f on Z.
7. **IMO 2008 Problem 4** ⋆⋆⋆
   Choose w, x, y, z so that the condition gives f(t) in terms of f(1/t) or $f(t^2)$, then beware the pointwise trap.

Kevinvariant
kevinvariant08.github.io

8. **IMO 2015 Problem 5** ⋆⋆⋆⋆

   Find $f(0)$ and the points where $f(x) = x$, then study the substitution with $x = 1$.

9. **USAMO 2016 Problem 4** ⋆⋆⋆⋆

   Guess the answers, find the zeros of f, and expect a pointwise argument at the end.

10. **IMO 2017 Problem 2** ⋆⋆⋆⋆

    Locate the zeros of f first, then prove injectivity for nonzero solutions.

Kevinvariant
kevinvariant08.github.io

4 Hints

1. Show that f is surjective, then substitute an m with $f(m) = 1$.
2. Find $f(0)$ using the zero of f, then replace y by $f(z)$ and choose z well.
3. Show that f takes every value in $[f(0), \infty)$, and use this to show that $f - f(0)$ is additive.
4. Show that f is an involution and, using that every real number is a cube, that f is additive. Then substitute $x \mapsto x + 1$ and $x \mapsto -x$ in the relation for $f(x^3)$.
5. Show that f is additive. Then expand $f\big((x+q)^3\big) = f(x+q)^3$ for rational q and compare coefficients of powers of q.
6. Show that $f - f(0)$ is additive. Then compare the equation at x and at $-x$, and do not forget constant solutions.

5 Solutions

Problem 1

Find all functions $f : \mathbb{Z} \to \mathbb{Z}$ such that $f\big(f(m) + n\big) = m + f(n+2)$ for all integers m, n.

The solutions are $f(n) = n + 2$ and $f(n) = 2 - n$. Check. For $f(n) = n + 2$ both sides equal $m + n + 4$, and for $f(n) = 2 - n$ the left side is $f(2 - m + n) = m - n$ and the right side is $m + \big(2 - (n+2)\big) = m - n$.

Conversely, putting $n = 0$ gives $f(f(m)) = m + f(2)$, and the right side takes every integer value as m varies, so f is surjective. Choose u with $f(u) = 1$. Putting $m = u$ gives $f(n+1) = u + f(n+2)$ for all n, that is, $f(k+1) - f(k) = -u$ for every integer k. Hence $f(n) = b + dn$ with $b = f(0)$ and $d = -u$.

Substituting into the equation, the left side is $b + d(b + dm + n) = d^2m + dn + db + b$ and the right side is $m + b + dn + 2d$. Comparing coefficients of m gives $d^2 = 1$, and comparing constants gives $db = 2d$, so $b = 2$. Hence $f(n) = n + 2$ or $f(n) = 2 - n$, and both were checked above.

Problem 2

Find all functions $f : \mathbb{R} \to \mathbb{R}$ such that $f\big(xf(y) + f(x)\big) = xy$ for all real x, y.

The only solution is $f(x) = 1 - x$. Check. $xf(y) + f(x) = x - xy + 1 - x = 1 - xy$, and $f(1 - xy) = xy$.

Write $P(x, y)$ for the equation. If $f(a) = f(b)$, then $P(1, a)$ and $P(1, b)$ give $a = b$, so f is injective. Next $P(1, y)$ shows f takes every real value y, so f is surjective. Let $c = f(0)$. $P(0, y)$ gives $f(c) = 0$. $P(x, c)$ gives $f(f(x)) = cx$, and then $x = c$ gives $f(0) = c^2$, so $c = c^2$.

If $c = 0$, then $f(f(x)) = 0 = f(f(0))$ for all x, and injectivity (applied twice) gives $x = 0$ for all x, which is absurd. Hence $c = 1$, so $f(0) = 1$, $f(1) = 0$ and $f(f(x)) = x$.

Now $P(x, f(z))$ gives $f\big(xz + f(x)\big) = xf(z)$, and with $z = 1$ this is $f\big(x + f(x)\big) = 0 = f(1)$. By injectivity $x + f(x) = 1$, so $f(x) = 1 - x$ for every x.

Kevinvariant
kevinvariant08.github.io

Problem 3

Prove that there is no function $f : \mathbb{R} \to \mathbb{R}$ such that $f(x + f(y)) = f(x) + y^2$ for all real x, y.

Suppose such an f exists and let $c = f(0)$. Putting $x = 0$ gives $f(f(y)) = c + y^2$, so f takes every value in $[c, \infty)$. Let S be the set of values of f, so $[c, \infty) \subseteq S$.

For $t \in S$, say $t = f(y)$, the equation reads $f(x + t) = f(x) + y^2$, and $y^2 = f(f(y)) - c = f(t) - c$. Hence, with $g = f - c$,

$$g(x + t) = g(x) + g(t) \quad \text{for all real } x \text{ and all } t \in S.$$

We show that g is additive. Given real x, u, choose $T \geq \max(c, c - u)$, so that $T \in S$ and $u + T \in S$. Then

$$g(x + u) + g(T) = g(x + u + T) = g(x) + g(u + T) = g(x) + g(u) + g(T),$$

using the displayed rule with $t = T$, then $t = u + T$, then $t = T$ again (with x replaced by u). Hence $g(x + u) = g(x) + g(u)$, and in particular $g(0) = 0$.

Now $f(f(y)) = c + y^2$ becomes $g\big(g(y) + c\big) + c = c + y^2$, that is, $g(g(y)) + g(c) = y^2$. With $y = 0$ this gives $g(c) = 0$, so $g(g(y)) = y^2$. But $g \circ g$ is additive, so $g(g(2)) = 2g(g(1))$, which says $4 = 2$. This contradiction shows that no such f exists.

Problem 4

Find all functions $f : \mathbb{R} \to \mathbb{R}$ such that $f\big(x^3 + f(y)\big) = xf(x^2) + y$ for all real x, y.

The solutions are $f(x) = x$ and $f(x) = -x$. Check. For $f(x) = x$ both sides equal $x^3 + y$, and for $f(x) = -x$ the left side is $f(x^3 - y) = y - x^3$ and the right side is $x \cdot (-x^2) + y = y - x^3$.

Write $P(x, y)$ for the equation. $P(0, y)$ gives $f(f(y)) = y$, so f is a bijection. Let $c = f(0)$. $P(x, f(t))$ gives $f(x^3 + t) = xf(x^2) + f(t)$, and with $t = 0$ this is $f(x^3) = xf(x^2) + c$. Subtracting, $f(x^3 + t) = f(x^3) + f(t) - c$ for all x, t. Every real number is a cube, so $g = f - c$ satisfies $g(s + t) = g(s) + g(t)$ for all real s, t. In terms of g, the relation $f(x^3) = xf(x^2) + c$ reads $g(x^3) = xg(x^2) + cx$, and $x = 1$ gives $c = 0$. Hence f is additive (so odd), and $f(x^3) = xf(x^2)$ for all x.

Let $a = f(1)$. Replacing x by $x + 1$ in $f(x^3) = xf(x^2)$ and expanding with additivity:

$$f(x^3) + 3f(x^2) + 3f(x) + a = (x + 1)\big(f(x^2) + 2f(x) + a\big).$$

Cancelling $f(x^3) = xf(x^2)$ leaves $2f(x^2) + f(x) = 2xf(x) + ax$. Replacing x by $-x$, which changes the sign of $f(x)$ and leaves $f(x^2)$ unchanged, gives $2f(x^2) - f(x) = 2xf(x) - ax$. Subtracting, $f(x) = ax$ for every x. Then $f(f(y)) = a^2y = y$, so $a = \pm 1$, and both functions were checked above.

Problem 5

Find all functions $f : \mathbb{R} \to \mathbb{R}$ such that $f(x^3 + y) = f(x)^3 + f(y)$ for all real x, y.

The solutions are $f(x) = 0$, $f(x) = x$ and $f(x) = -x$. Each works, since $(\pm x)^3 = \pm x^3$, so in each case both sides equal $f(x^3) + f(y)$ with f linear.

Kevinvariant
kevinvariant08.github.io

Putting $x = 0$ gives $f(0)^3 = 0$, so $f(0) = 0$, and putting $y = 0$ gives $f(x^3) = f(x)^3$. So the equation reads $f(x^3 + y) = f(x^3) + f(y)$, and since every real number is a cube, f is additive. Hence $f(qx) = qf(x)$ for rational q. Let $a = f(1)$. Then $a = f(1^3) = a^3$, so $a \in \{-1, 0, 1\}$.

Fix a real x and let q be rational. Expanding with additivity,

$$f\big((x+q)^3\big) = f(x^3) + 3q\,f(x^2) + 3q^2 f(x) + q^3 a, \qquad f(x+q)^3 = \big(f(x) + qa\big)^3 = f(x)^3 + 3qa\,f(x)^2 + 3q^2a^2 f(x) + q^3a^3.$$

These are equal for every rational q, and both are polynomials in q, so their coefficients agree. The coefficient of q^2 gives $f(x) = a^2 f(x)$, and that of q gives $f(x^2) = af(x)^2$.

If $a = 0$, the first relation gives $f(x) = 0$ for all x. If $a = \pm 1$, let $h = af$. Then h is additive and $h(x^2) = a^2 f(x)^2 = f(x)^2 \geq 0$, so $h \geq 0$ on $[0, \infty)$. By Theorem 1 (with h bounded below on $(0, 1)$), $h(x) = h(1)x = a^2 x = x$, so $f(x) = ax$. This gives $f(x) = x$ and $f(x) = -x$.

Problem 6

Find all functions $f : \mathbb{R} \to \mathbb{R}$ such that $f(x^2 + y) + f(x) = f(x)f(x+1) + f(y)$ for all real x, y.

The solutions are $f(x) = 0$, $f(x) = 1$ and $f(x) = x$. Check. For $f(x) = 0$ both sides are 0, for $f(x) = 1$ both sides are 2, and for $f(x) = x$ the left side is $x^2 + y + x$ and the right side is $x(x+1) + y$.

Write $P(x, y)$ for the equation and let $c = f(0)$. Subtracting $P(x, 0)$ from $P(x, y)$ gives $f(x^2 + y) = f(x^2) + f(y) - c$, so $g = f - c$ satisfies $g(t + y) = g(t) + g(y)$ for all $t \geq 0$ and all real y. We show that g is additive. Taking $t = y = 0$ gives $g(0) = 0$. For $t < 0$, the rule applied to $-t > 0$ gives $0 = g(0) = g(-t) + g(t)$ and $g(y) = g\big((y + t) + (-t)\big) = g(y + t) + g(-t)$. Together these give $g(y + t) = g(y) + g(t)$. So g is additive, and in particular odd.

Let $b = g(1)$, so that $f(x + 1) = g(x) + b + c$. Substituting $f = g + c$ into $P(x, 0)$, that is $f(x^2) + f(x) = f(x)f(x + 1) + c$, and expanding,

$$g(x^2) = g(x)^2 + (b + 2c - 1)\,g(x) + c(b + c - 1). \qquad (1)$$

Replacing x by $-x$ changes the sign of $g(x)$ and leaves $g(x^2)$ unchanged, so subtracting the two versions of (1) gives $2(b + 2c - 1)g(x) = 0$ for every x.

If g is identically zero, f is the constant c, and the equation becomes $2c = c^2 + c$, so $c = 0$ or $c = 1$.

Otherwise $g(x_0) \neq 0$ for some x_0, so $b + 2c = 1$. Putting $x = 0$ in (1) gives $c(b + c - 1) = 0$, so (1) becomes $g(x^2) = g(x)^2$. Hence $g \geq 0$ on $[0, \infty)$, and by Theorem 1 (with g bounded below on $(0, 1)$), $g(x) = bx$ for all x. Now $x = 1$ in $g(x^2) = g(x)^2$ gives $b = b^2$, and $b \neq 0$ because g is not identically zero, so $b = 1$ and $c = \frac{1-b}{2} = 0$. This gives $f(x) = x$.

Note that the constant solution $f(x) = 1$ is easy to lose, since this solution has $g = 0$ and so appears only in the first case.

L5-AL2 · © 2026 Kevin Hu · kevinvariant08.github.io · CC BY-NC-ND 4.0

Kevinvariant
kevinvariant08.github.io